EKKLESIA: A NEW PARADIGM IN PAULINE CONCEPT KINGDOM OF GOD

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1. Introduction

Kingdom of God is a very popular theme among the Christians. Its popularity could be connected with its eschatological nature; inbuilt with hope for a better life in the realm of the Kingdom of God. But, discussions on the kingdom are often associated with Jesus and the Gospels, and a study in Pauline concept of the kingdom is often neglected. People who drew most of their emphasis on the Gospel may draw the conclusion that there is a marked distinction between Jesus' concept of the kingdom and Paul's theology.

In NT Studies, there has been a long debate on the nature of the Kingdom of God; whether it has been an inaugurated kingdom or one which awaits consummation in the future, or both. For a long time, Pauline studies centred around this debate. While Paul speaks of the kingdom of God as if it were a present reality capable of being experienced by the Christian believers (Rom 14:17 and 1 Cor 4:20), there are other passages where he speaks of the kingdom of God as it were a future hope (1 Thess 1:10; 2:12 and 2:19). He also often speaks of it as something which will be inherited by the faithful (1 Cor 6:9-10; 15:50; Gal 5:21). The language of future inheritance is also found in Colossians 3:24 (cf. Col 1:12) and Eph 5:5. Thus for Kreitzer and many other scholars in this line of thought, it is not possible to restrict Paul's teaching about the kingdom of God/Christ to temporal terms, but to something which straddles the dimensions of time, being both present and future.[1]

This paper will be a humble attempt to explore the theme of Kingdom of God in Pauline epistles with two-fold objectives. *Firstly,* the role that it plays in the context of Paul's time, re-situating the theme under the historical and specifically political context of the Roman Empire; *secondly,* Paul's attempt to shift the kingdom of the Roman Empire to God's reign, as a resistance to the Roman Imperial Order and.

[1] L.J. Kreitzer, "Kingdom of God/Christ," *Dictionary of Paul and his Letters*, edited by Gerald F. Hawthorne, Ralph R. Martin, Daniel G. Reid (Illinois: InterVarsity Press, 1993), 525.

2. Background of Kingdom of God

The term 'Kingdom' comes from a Greek word βασιλεία which means 'to be king', the position or power of the king. Another meaning emphasises the geographical aspects of the reign, the kingdom. The LXX used this term to translate the Hebrew *mal^{e}k̲ût*, which means kingdom or reign where the reference is to power rather than locality.[2] Thus, 'Kingdom of God' is to mean not just the reign of God in terms of geographical dimension, but the authority and power of God. This concept is central in Biblical studies.

In the Pauline corpus, even though the idea of the kingdom of God or kingdom of Christ is central to the whole of Paul's thought, there are only a few direct references to "the kingdom" within the Pauline letters.[3] The term *basileia* ("reign," "kingdom") occurs only fifteen times,[4] while the verb *basileuō* ("to reign") occurs nine times[5] and the verb *symbasileuō* ("to reign with") occurs in 1 Timothy 2:12. The phrase "kingdom of God" (or its equivalent) occurs a mere eight times within the Pauline letters.[6] The reference to "our citizenship is in heaven" *(to politeuma en ouranois)* in Philippians 3:20 might also legitimately be understood as a parallel expression. Another startling fact is that within the Pauline corpus the kingdom *of Christ* is only explicitly described in Colossians 1:13 and Ephesians 5:5.[7]

When Paul uses the term "kingdom" he does not define it, indicating that his audiences probably had prior knowledge about its meaning and relevance in their physical and religious life.[8]

3. The Political World of Paul

After series of domination and subjugation under the Babylonians and then the Persians, the land of the Judean peasantry was once again subjected to the conquest of the giant Alexander

[2] B. Klappert, "King, kingdom, βασιλεία" *The New International Dictionary of New Testament Theology*, Vol. 2, edited by Colin Brown (Exeter: The Paternoster Press, 1976), 376.
[3] There are 13 Epistles in the New Testament accredited to the authorship of Paul. Scholars are debating on the authenticity of Pauline authorship. According to R.E. Brown, from the 13, 7 epistles (I Thessalonians, Galatians, Philippians, Philemon, I Corinthians, II Corinthians, Romans) are widely accepted as genuinely Paul's, while 3 of them (II Thessalonians, Colossians, Ephesians) are debatable, the other three, also known as the Pastoral Epistles (Titus, I Timothy, II Timothy) are even more of a concern. Cf. Raymond E. Brown, *An Introduction to The New Testament* (Bangalore: Theological Publications in India, 2000), 407.
[4] Rom 14:17; 1 Cor 4:20; 6:9, 10; 15:24, 50; Gal 5:21; Eph 5:5; Col 1:13; 4:11; 1 Thess 2:12; 2 Thess 1:5; 2 Tim 4:1, 14,18
[5] Rom 5:14, 17 (twice), 21(twice); 6:12; 1 Cor 4:8 (twice); 15:25
[6] Rom 14:17; 1 Cor 4:20; 6:9; 15:50; Gal 5:21; Col 4:11; 1 Thess 2:12 ("his kingdom"); 2 Thess 1:5
[7] Kreitzer, "Kingdom of God/Christ," 525.
[8] Michael J. Vlach, "The Kingdom of God in Paul's Epistles," *MSJ*, 26/1 (Spring, 2015): 59.

the Great in 332 BCE.[9] The Hellenistic empires of Alexander's successors brought a systematic program of increased economic exploitation and a general policy of cultural imperialism that threatened the Jews' traditional ways of life.[10] Even the century long Hasmonean Dynasty (142-62 BCE) could not suppress the cultural imperialism of the Hellenists. Roman domination of Jewish Palestine began with a violent conquest followed by a prolonged period of devastating power struggles. Pompey's conquest of Palestine in 63 BCE, the Jewish territories were continuously under Roman control. Pompey besieged Jerusalem, "liberated" and restored the Hellenistic cities and other areas of Palestine that had been conquered and Judaized by the Hasmoneans. The remaining Jewish territories (Galilee, Perea, Idumea, along with Judea) were subjected to the tribute; with repeated devastation of the land, extraordinary levies of taxes, and general social turmoil.[11]

Even though there were commanders and rulers for the empire prior to Augustus (31 BCE-14 AD), he was the first one to receive the supreme glory of ruling a unified empire, and by the end of his reign, the kingdom had as many as 25 legions and by the middle of the first century in complimenting the legions, more than 3,00,000 soldiers served the Roman army. [12] Amidst their glorious regime, their prime interest was purely Roman interest, and intervention occurred when such the Roman interest was threatened.[13] The world, in which Paul was born, lived and worked was under total subjugation and hegemony of the Roman Empire.

Paul was thus a product of the three aforementioned identities: A Jewish by birth, "circumcised on the eighth day, a member of the people of Israel, of the tribe of Benjamin, a Hebrew born of Hebrews; as to the law, a Pharisee" (Phil 3:5); a Greek speaker and a citizen of the Hellenised city of Tarsus (Acts 21:39) and also a Roman citizen (Acts 22:28).[14] Apart from his final journey to Rome, Paul's world was limited to the eastern Roman Empire,[15] and most of his ministry were in the cities and he was able to travel by sea. Paul's time was the era when the Roman Empire was at its peak.

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[9] Theodore N. Swanson, *When the Time had Fully Come* (Philadelphia: Parish Life Press, 1982), 14.
[10] Richard Horsley & John S. Hanson, *Bandits, Prophets and Messiahs: Popular Movements in the Time of Jesus* (Harrisburg: Trinity Press International, 1999), 10.
[11] Horsley, *Bandits, Prophets and Messiahs*, 30-31.
[12] Richard J. Cassidy, *Christians and Roman Rule in the New Testament: New Perspective* (New York: The Crossroad Publishing Company, 2001), 6-9.
[13] B.M. Rapske, "Roman Empire, Christians and the" in *Dictionary of the Later New Testament & its Development*, edited by Ralph P. Martin & Peter H. Davids (Downers Grove: InterVarsity Press, 1997), 1059.
[14] Richard Wallace and Wynne Williams, *The Three Worlds of Paul of Tarsus* (London: Routledge, 1998), 4-6.
[15] With the possible exception of his stay in Arabia, mentioned in Galatians 1:17, which possibly refer to the kingdom of the Nabateans, formally independent but actually within Rome's 'sphere of influence'. Wallace, *The Three Worlds of Paul of Tarsus*, 8.

3. Elements of Imperialism in Pauline Epistles

Christian interpretation has long perpetuated the assumption that the core of Paul's theology was opposed to "the Jews and their understanding of salvation." The traditional picture of Paul thus concentrated with individual salvation and "justification" before God more than justice toward the poor and oppressed.[16] Thus, from this line of thought, the concept of the Kingdom of God is also very much linked with the ideology.

However, in the previous century, the interpretation of Paul shifted from the traditional spiritual salvific concern as against Judaism's understanding of being in the covenant to the "New Perspective of Paul." Scholars like N.T. Wright, E.P. Sanders and J.D.G Dunn shifted from the traditional interpretation Paul's opponents.[17] This revolution in Pauline studies drastically changes the understanding of Paul from Anti-Judaism to Anti-Romans. Paul's gospel of Christ announced doom and destruction not on Judaism or the Law, but on the "rulers of this age (I Cor 2:6-8)."[18] The new line of thought thus, provoked studies to understand him in his Roman imperial background.

Paul wrote all his epistles during the subjugation of the Roman Empire. Even though his identity as a Jew was written by himself, his other identities were mentioned for him by Luke in Acts of the Apostles. Luke also mentioned a number of advantages that Paul had due to his identity as a Roman. However, in his own letters, Paul prides himself on how frequently he was hauled before civic magistrates and Roman officials, thrown into prison and trialed in Roman courts.

John Dominic Crossan and Jonathan L. Reed's book, *In Search of Paul: How Jesus' Apostle Opposed Rome's Empire with God's Kingdom* emphasize the idea that in order to properly understand the critique of Roman imperialism that Paul offers in his writings, it is first necessary to grasp the implications of imperial propaganda. Paul's use of political terms from the official Roman ideology, such as *ekklesia, euaggelion, basileia, kyrios, parousia, soter* and *apantesis*, all of which are indelibly associated with the official image and functions of the Roman emperor, as well as with the Pauline presentation of Christianity, is not accidental

[16] Niel Elliott, "The Apostle Paul and Empire," *In the Shadow of Empire*, edited by Richard A. Horsley (Louisville: Westminster John Knox Press, 2008), 101.
[17] S.J. Hafemann, "Paul and his Interpreters," *Dictionary of Paul and his Letters*, edited by Gerald F. Hawthorne, Ralph R. Martin, Daniel G. Reid (Illinois: InterVarsity Press, 1993), 672-675.
[18] Richard Horsley, ed. *Paul and Empire: Religion and Power in Roman Imperial Society* (Harrisburg: Trinity Press International, 1997), 6.

or insignificant. On the contrary, it is precisely in the context of the official imperial representations and terminology that Pauline presentation of Christianity can be properly understood. For example, Paul's adoption and appropriation of the official titles of the Roman emperor as divine, as a "son of God" (*dei filius; divi filius*), implicate a direct opposition between Christ and Caesar and indicate treason on part of early Christians as against the Roman empire. According to Crossan and Reed, Paul's version of the gospel is viewed with suspicion by the Roman authorities, as it is directly opposed to the reigning Roman practice of attaining "peace through victory." The ideological and practical clash between the two visions of "peace" that are represented by Paul and by the official Roman propaganda rests on the different terms and conditions for the two. Whereas *Pax Romana* necessitates the establishment and sustenance of peace through military conquest and victory, the alternative vision that Paul introduces is *shalom* or "peace through justice;" while one is conditioned by hierarchy and subordination, the other is marked by equality and service.[19]

4. Kingdom of God in Paul

4.1. Kingdom of God as resistance to the Emperor Cult

During the 50s CE, Paul moved systematically through eastern Mediterranean cities such as Philippi, Thessalonica and Corinth proclaiming the Gospel of Christ. Yet, that was the time when the "Gospel of Caesar" was becoming widespread and well-established in those cities, because Emperor Worship was very common. In such a condition Paul assured the Philippians to expect a "Saviour from heaven" from where they have citizenship (Phil 3:20); a citizenship in the Kingdom of God. [20] Paul's most striking opposition of the imperial gospel was that Jupiter and the gods had handed power over to Augustus. But for Paul he insisted that Christ was now reigning in heaven and, "after every rule and every authority and power," would "hand the kingdom over to God the Father…so that God may be all in all" (I Cor 15:24, 28).[21] Acknowledging that the Emperors are human beings and are perishable, he concluded, **"**flesh and blood cannot inherit the kingdom of God, nor does the perishable inherit the imperishable**"** (I Cor 15:50).

[19] Stamenka Emilova Antonova, review of *In Search of Paul: How Jesus' Apostle Opposed Rome's Empire with God's Kingdom. A New Vision of Paul's Words & World*, by John Dominic Crossan and Jonathan L. Reed, *Union Seminary Quarterly Review* 59/3-4 (2005), 200.
[20] Horsley, ed. *Paul and Empire*, 3.
[21] Horsley, ed. *Paul and Empire*, 147.

4.2. Kingdom of God as an alternate society to the Roman reign

The reign of the Roman Empire was "flourishing" and there was "prosperity" and "peace" in the empire. But these very identities of the Roman Empire were not for the periphery of the Society, but only for a few Roman elites. Even though *Pax Romana* was portrayed by Acts of the Apostles as immensely aiding the spread of the Gospel (1:8), in reality it was at the cost of the freedom of the subjugated ones. The Roman military violence established the material, political and cultural conditions in which NT world was built. Throughout Romans, Paul compares the Roman Empire with that of the Kingdom of God, starting in 1:3-4 where he introduced Jesus as the true king, using the law of royal succession.[22] In Romans 14, he gives practical examples for the realisation of the solidarity of God, and in verse 17 specifically compared the Kingdom of the Romans with that of God's Kingdom. Since the Roman empire was that of oppression, subjugation, inequality and social evils, Paul wrote that the alternate kingdom, the kingdom of God "righteousness and peace and joy in the Holy Spirit" (Rom 14:17), will not be a place for "Fornicators, idolaters, adulterers, male prostitutes, sodomites, thieves, the greedy, drunkards, revilers, robbers" (I Cor 6:8,9; Gal 5: 19-21). These characteristics are commonly seen and experienced in the unjust and immoral Roman rule.

4.3. Kingdom of God as hope for the future in the midst of the subjugation under the Roman Empire

The futuristic or apocalyptic nature of Pauline's Kingdom of God is also seen in the context of oppression that they were suffering under the tyrannical Roman Empire. By mid first century CE the Julio-Claudian dynasty became a parody of kinship, receiving threats from foreign entities like the Parthians.[23] After Nero's people murdered the Governor and ascended the throne, Paul was arrested sometime in the fall of 54 CE. In the ruthless world of Nero, competition of individuals for economic survival and social status thrived. Horsley believed that the collection for "the poor among the saints in Jerusalem" to be a clear evidence of the dominant ethos during that time.[24] In such a situation, we see a vivid illustration of an apocalyptic scenario or master-narrative of subjugated people, currently subject to the imperial order, who will imminently share in the divine judgment of their

[22] Dieter Georgi, "God Turned Upside Down," *Paul and Empire: Religion and Power in Roman Imperial Society*, edited by Richard A. Horsley (Harrisburg: Trinity Press International, 1997), 151.
[23] Richard A. Horsley and Neil Asher Silberman, *The Message and the Kingdom: How Jesus and Paul Ignited a Revolution and Transformed the Ancient World* (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 1997), 180.
[24] Horsley, *The Message and the Kingdom*, 185.

unrighteous oppressors, as they enter the participatory popular sovereignty of the kingdom of God (1 Cor 6:2-3, 9-11).[25]

Abraham Smith proposed that, deployment of apocalyptic tradition is one form of resistance of the Empire,[26] thus Paul urges and encourages the Thessalonians to be patient and live a life, worthy of God, "who calls you into his own kingdom and glory" (I Thess 2:12; II Thess 1:5).

4.4. Ekklesia: A new paradigm in the Kingdom of God

Another form of resistance in Paul, proposed by Smith is *cultivation of 'assemblies'* in the form of *ekklesia*.[27] The term *ekklesia* (ἐκκλησία) is derived from *ek-kaleo,* which was used for the summons to the army to assemble, from *ek,* out and *kaleo,* to call. It is attested from 5th century B.C.E. and denotes the popular assembly of the competent full citizens of the *polis,* city. It reached its greatest importance in the 5th century and met at regular intervals (in Athens about 30-40 times a year, elsewhere less frequently) and also in cases of urgency as an extra-ordinary *ekklesia.*[28]

Ekklesia is the principal term that Paul uses with reference both to the movement as a whole and to the particular local communities. Even though it is widely accepted that Pauline *Ekklesia* comes from the Septuagint with strong connotations of the "assembly" of (all) Israel, its primary meaning in the Greek-speaking eastern Roman empire was the citizen "assembly" of the Greek *polis.* It is thus, a political term with certain religious overtones.[29] Paul evidently understood the *ekklesia* of a Thessalonica or Corinth not as a "cultic community," but as the political assembly of the people "in Christ" coming together and "competition" with the official city assembly. He also re-establishes a community for the poor residents of Greek cities, a replacement for the old Greek democratic assemblies, which

[25] Richard A. Horsley, "The First and Second Letters to the Corinthians," *The Postcolonial Commentary on the New Testament Writings,* edited by Fernando F. Segovia and R.S. Sugirtharajah, 231.
[26] Abraham Smith, "The First and Second Letter to the Thessalonians,"*The Postcolonial Commentary on the New Testament Writings,* edited by Fernando F. Segovia and R.S. Sugirtharajah, 310.
[27] Smith, "The First and Second Letter to the Thessalonians,"310.
[28] Lothar Coenen, "Church, Synagogue," *The New International Dictionary of New Testament Theology, Vol. 1,* edited by Colin Brown (Grand Rapids, Michigan: Regency Reference Library, 1975), 291.
[29] Horsley, ed. *Paul and Empire*, 208.

the Romans had attempted to eliminate.[30] Paul's *ekklesiai* are thus local communities of an alternative society of the Kingdom of God, to the Roman imperial order.[31]

Moreover, under the Roman Empire, a person's adherence to a cult of a god or goddess represented membership to a particular nation. And for those who were alienated from or uncomfortable with their former social identities in the day-to-day life under the Empire, found the *ekklesiai* of the Jesus Movement to be desirable alternative community.[32] Thus Horsley also argued that the conditions of poverty and powerlessness attracted the Jewish peasants and townspeople, the neglected among the Gentiles to seek relief and escape in the expectation of the Kingdom of God through membership in the Jesus Movement, in the *ekklesia.*[33]

5. Conclusion

Who are the group of people who stubbornly refuse to offer patriotic sacrifices to the Roman Imperial regime? What is the "Kingdom" that they claim loyalty to? For Paul, the Kingdom of God is the down-to-earth response to an oppressive and tyrannical ideology of earthly power that had disrupted their economy, their political independence and freedom. Thus, his search for an alternate society, an alternate kingdom is evidently found in his epistles; a society here on earth and also even after. *Ekklesia* is thus, the paradigm for the Kingdom of God, where Christ reigns and is revered, an alternate society where the evils of the Roman Empire cease to exist. Therefore Paul assured those who became members of the Kingdom of God "*ekklesia*", through Christ, where, there is no longer Jew or Greek, … slave or free, … male and female; where all are one in Christ Jesus, (Gal 3:28) as against the tyrannical, unjust and prejudiced Roman Empire.

[30] Efrain Agosto, "Patronage and Commendation, Imperial and Anti-Imperial," *Paul and the Roman Imperial Order,* edited by Richard Horsley (Harrisburg: Trinity Press International, 2004), 109.
[31] Horsley, ed. *Paul and Empire*, 208.
[32] Horsley, *The Message and the Kingdom*, 118.
[33] Horsley, *The Message and the Kingdom*, 119.

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